

Technology, authenticity, and communicative competence: Unpacking learner perceptions



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Abstract This study investigates the relationship between students' perceptions of authentic material use and their desire for greater technology integration in foreign language instruction in Albanian higher secondary education. Conducted under the national research project "The Impact of the 'Competence-Based Teaching' Curriculum on the Development of Communicative and Expressive Competence Among Foreign Language Students" (AKKSHI), the research explores how these two instructional components contribute to the development of communicative competence and learner engagement in language learning. A total of 1,119 students from various school years and language proficiency levels participated by completing a structured questionnaire containing Likert-scale items. Statistical analysis using Spearman's rho revealed a weak but statistically significant positive correlation ($\rho = .132$, $p < .001$) between students' perceptions of authentic materials and their support for more technology use in the classroom. Additionally, one-sample t tests showed that students' ratings of both variables were significantly below the neutral midpoint, indicating that learners perceived current instructional practices as underutilizing both real-world materials and technological tools. These findings point to a notable gap between students' preferences and existing pedagogical approaches in language teaching. The study contributes to the understanding of how authenticity and digital tools can be jointly leveraged to improve communicative and expressive competence. It suggests that students who value exposure to authentic content may also be more receptive to digital innovations that enhance the delivery and interaction with such materials. The implications are particularly relevant for curriculum developers, teacher training programs, and educational policymakers, especially in contexts with limited prior integration of technology. The research underscores the importance of balanced, student-centered teaching approaches that combine pedagogical authenticity with accessible technological resources. Future research should explore additional moderating factors such as digital literacy, teacher preparedness, and infrastructural access to better understand the dynamics between teaching practices and learner expectations in foreign language education.

Keywords: authentic materials, technology integration, foreign language education, communicative competence, student perceptions

1. Introduction

In the field of foreign language teaching, educators continuously seek innovative methods to enhance students' linguistic abilities and communicative competence (Rivers, 1973). One such method is the integration of *authentic materials* and *technology* (Shlowiy & Lidawan, 2019), both of which have been shown to foster deeper engagement, improve comprehension, and provide learners with a real-world context that is essential for acquiring practical language skills (Balalle, 2024a). While much of the global discourse around these methods has concentrated on general language education, Albanian higher secondary education remains a relatively underexplored area, particularly with respect to the impact these factors have on foreign language learners.

Authentic materials are defined as texts and media produced for purposes other than language instruction (Danansooriya, 2022). They are valued for providing exposure to natural language use, varied discourse structures, and cultural contexts (Kozhevnikova, 2014). Research has shown that such materials can increase learners' motivation, comprehension skills, and confidence in using the target language (School of Languages and General Education, Walailak University, Thailand & Treve, 2023a).

Moreover, the use of technology has gained prominence in language teaching (Motteram, 2013). Technology can facilitate access to authentic content, support collaboration, and allow for multimodal expression, all of which are believed to enrich the learning experience (Mhlongo et al., 2023). However, learners' attitudes toward technology integration vary and are often shaped by their prior experiences and pedagogical preferences.



Despite the growing body of research supporting both strategies, few studies have examined how students' appreciation of authentic materials may be related to their desire for more technology in the classroom. Understanding this relationship can offer insights into learner preferences and guide more effective, blended approaches to language instruction.

In recent years, the Albanian educational system has been working toward enhancing the quality of foreign language education through initiatives such as the *competence-based teaching* curriculum (Nikolov et al., 2014). This curriculum focuses on developing a broader set of skills among students, with an emphasis on fostering *communicative and expressive competence* (Anderson-Levitt et al., 2017). Therefore, investigating how these elements interact and contribute to language learning outcomes is essential.

This research is conducted within the framework of the project "The impact of the 'Competence-Based Teaching' curriculum on the development of communicative and expressive competence among foreign language students in Albanian higher secondary education," a project funded by the National Agency for Scientific Research and Innovation (AKKSHI). For this purpose, a questionnaire consisting of seven sections was developed, which contains questions regarding communicative competence in a foreign language, problems and challenges during communication, strategies and techniques used in the classroom, and what they would like to change, regarding improving the development of communication and expression skills in a foreign language. From these sections, two variables were taken into analysis to be presented in this study:

The use of authentic materials in the classroom, as reflected in students' perceptions, improved their understanding of the foreign language.

The desire for increased technological integration in teaching practices, specifically how students perceive the role of technology in facilitating their language learning, and whether they would like to see more technology incorporated into their lessons.

The research uses a *Likert scale* to assess students' attitudes and perceptions regarding these two components, enabling a clear understanding of the extent to which students feel that authentic materials enhance their comprehension and whether they believe that technology could further improve their language learning experience.

Study analysis designs:

To assess the relationship between teachers' use of authentic materials and students' desire for more technology in language teaching. This includes understanding how the integration of authentic materials (such as videos, articles, and audio) influences students' perceptions of the role of technology in language learning.

To determine the strength and direction of the correlation between two variables: the use of authentic materials and the desire for more technology in the classroom. Through correlation analysis, the study seeks to uncover whether students who appreciate authentic materials also express a preference for greater technology use in language education.

To evaluate whether there is a statistically significant difference in the responses to the two statements regarding authentic materials and technology. Using a t-test, the research aims to determine if there is a meaningful difference in the mean responses to the two questions, providing insights into the relative importance of these factors for students.

To explore the implications of integrating authentic materials and technology in improving communicative and expressive competence in foreign language education. By examining students' views, this study aims to provide recommendations for enhancing language teaching practices that align with student preferences and educational objectives.

2. Literature Review

The integration of *authentic materials* and *technology* in language teaching has been extensively discussed in educational research because of its potential to enhance student engagement, improve language acquisition, and foster communicative competence.

2.1. Authentic Materials in Language Teaching

Authentic materials are resources created for native speakers of the target language, such as newspapers, radio programs, videos, websites, and podcasts, that are used in the language classroom to expose students to real-life language use (Gilmore, 2007a). The use of authentic materials in language teaching has been shown to provide students with contextualized language exposure, making learning more relevant and engaging (Toma, 2022). Such materials help bridge the gap between the classroom and real-world language use, thereby fostering greater motivation and confidence among students (Dja'far, 2023).

Several studies have highlighted the positive impact of authentic materials on the development of *listening and reading skills* (School of Languages and General Education, Walailak University, Thailand & Treve, 2023b), (Assoc. Prof., Anadolu University, Turkey, sdbelet@anadolu.edu.tr et al., 2018). By interacting with authentic resources, students are exposed to natural speech patterns, idiomatic expressions, and cultural nuances, which enhance their ability to understand and use the language in practical situations (Gilmore, 2019).

In particular, the use of multimedia resources such as *video* and *audio* has been shown to improve listening comprehension and speaking ability (Uzun, 2023). These types of materials help students become familiar with different

accents, intonation patterns, and cultural contexts, which is crucial for acquiring a more holistic understanding of the language (Hongsa et al., 2024). Moreover, authentic materials align well with *communicative language teaching* (CLT), which emphasizes interaction and real-world communication as key components of language learning (Richards & Rodgers, 2001).

2.2. Technology in Language Teaching

Technology has increasingly become a powerful tool in the language classroom, with advancements in digital tools, online platforms, and multimedia resources providing teachers and students with new ways to engage with learning materials (Urbaite, 2024). The use of technology in language teaching includes a wide array of resources, such as interactive software, language learning apps, online resources, and digital classrooms (Huda et al., 2023). Research on the integration of technology in education consistently suggests that when used effectively, technology can improve both teaching and learning outcomes (Huda et al., 2023).

One significant advantage of incorporating technology into language teaching is the ability to provide students with personalized learning experiences. Language learning platforms and applications allow students to work at their own pace, receiving immediate feedback on their performance (Rebolledo Font De La Vall & González Araya, 2023a). Moreover, digital tools facilitate collaboration among students, providing them with opportunities to engage in online discussions, peer review activities, and project-based learning, which can enhance both their linguistic and collaborative skills (Professor, Director of TESOL Studies, Graduate School of International Culture & Communication Studies, Waseda University & Stockwell, 2021).

Furthermore, technology offers opportunities for interactive learning (Pradono et al., 2013), enabling students to engage with language content in ways that traditional methods may not. For example, virtual classrooms, online games, and digital storytelling allow students to immerse themselves in language practice, encouraging them to use the language creatively and interactively (Seymour & Walsh, 2006).

Despite the significant body of research on the individual effects of authentic materials and technology in language learning, there is a notable gap in the literature regarding the synergistic effects (Schindler, 2017) of these two factors when combined. While studies have explored their impact on language proficiency, few studies have specifically addressed how authentic materials and technology work together to enhance communicative and expressive competence in language learners. Additionally, the Albanian educational context remains underexplored in this regard, with limited empirical research on how these tools are integrated into the Albanian secondary education system.

This study aims to fill these gaps by investigating how the use of authentic materials, coupled with a desire for more technology in the classroom, influences the development of communicative competence and expressive competence among foreign language students in Albanian higher secondary education. By using both correlation analysis and t tests, this research explores the relationship between students' perceptions of authentic material usage and their attitudes toward the integration of more technology in language teaching.

3. Methodology

The methodology section of this study outlines the research design, data collection methods, and data analysis techniques employed to explore the impact of *authentic materials* and *technology* on the development of communicative and expressive competence among foreign language students in Albanian higher secondary education. This research aims to understand how students perceive the use of authentic materials and the integration of technology in language teaching and whether there is a correlation between these two factors.

3.1. Research Design

This study uses a quantitative research design, which is appropriate for examining relationships between variables and assessing the statistical significance of these relationships. The study focuses on two main variables:

Use of Authentic Materials: Students' perceptions of how frequently and effectively their teachers use authentic materials (e.g., videos, articles, audio) to enhance their understanding of the foreign language.

Desire for More Technology in Language Teaching: Students' attitudes toward incorporating technology into language instruction, specifically how they feel about the increased use of digital tools, multimedia, and online resources in the classroom.

3.2. Sample Selection

The study sample consists of higher secondary education students enrolled in Albanian. A stratified random sampling technique is used to ensure that students from different schools and different levels of language proficiency from different cities are represented in the study. Stratification ensures that both urban and rural schools are included in the sample to capture any potential differences in experiences due to geographic or educational disparities. The sample size for this study consists of 1119 students, which is determined based on the need to ensure statistical power for the analysis of correlations and t-tests (Table 1).

3.3. Data collection methods

To collect the necessary data, a questionnaire with two primary components was designed. The questionnaire includes two key statements on a Likert scale (from 1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree) designed to assess students' perceptions of the use of authentic materials and their desire for more technology in language classes. These statements are as follows:

Column A (Use of Authentic Materials): Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding. Column B (Desire for More Technology): I would like to see more technology used in teaching in language classes.

3.4. Demographic Information:

Age: 14–18-year-old students.

Table 1 School year.

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	I	390	34.9	34.9	34.9
	II	493	44.1	44.1	78.9
	III	236	21.1	21.1	100.0
	Total	1119	100.0	100.0	

This table summarizes the distribution of 1,119 students across three school years (I, II, and III):

Second-year students (IIs) represent the largest group, with 493 students, accounting for 44.1% of the total population. The first-year students (I) followed, with 390 students, accounting for 34.9% of the total. The third-year students (III) constitute the smallest group, with 236 students, or 21.1% of the total.

The Table 2 presents the distribution of 1,119 students according to their language proficiency level, categorized via the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR): A1, A2, B1, and B2. The majority of students fall within the elementary to lower-intermediate range:

The A2 level (basic user) includes the largest group, with 461 students, comprising 41.2% of the sample.

The A1 level (basic user, breakthrough) follows with 220 students (19.7%), indicating a significant proportion of beginners.

B1 (independent user, threshold) accounts for 288 students (25.7%).

B2 (upper intermediate) includes 150 students (13.4%), the smallest group in the sample.

Table 2 Knowledge level.

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	A1	220	19.7	19.7	19.7
	A2	461	41.2	41.2	60.9
	B1	288	25.7	25.7	86.6
	B2	150	13.4	13.4	100.0
	Total	1119	100.0	100.0	

3.5. Data analysis

The data collected from the questionnaire was entered into the statistical software program, SPSS (Statistical Package for the Social Sciences) for analysis. The following statistical techniques were employed:

Descriptive statistics: Descriptive statistics, including the mean, standard deviation, and frequency distributions, were used to summarize the responses to the Likert-scale questions and provide an overview of students' perceptions of authentic materials and technology use in language classes.

Both items were answered by 1119 participants, indicating complete data without missing responses (Table 3).

Table 3 Frequencies.

Statistics		Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding.		I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes.	
N	Valid	1119		1119	
	Missing	0		0	

This Table 3 presents the views of 1,119 students on their teachers' use of authentic materials like videos and articles. While 43.6% responded positively, the high rate of strong disagreement (29.8%) points to inconsistency in classroom practices. Only 5.8% strongly agreed, suggesting that even supportive students rarely see authentic materials used effectively or often. The 16.8% neutral responses may reflect limited understanding or exposure to such materials. Overall, the results reveal a gap

between teaching intentions and student perceptions, highlighting the need for clearer integration and communication of authentic resources in language instruction.

The responses reveal a divided student body regarding the role of technology in language instruction. A significant portion (38.3%) strongly disagrees with increasing technology use, possibly due to satisfaction with current methods, limited digital skills, or a preference for traditional approaches. In contrast, more than one-third (38.1%) support greater integration of technology, reflecting diverse preferences and learning styles. 15.7% who responded neutrally may be indifferent or unaware of how technology is currently used in their classrooms. These split highlights differing expectations among students. As such, educators may need to balance digital innovation with traditional methods to accommodate varying needs (Table 4 and 5).

Table 4 Perceptions of students.

Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding.					
		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	334	29.8	29.8	29.8
	Agree to some extent	109	9.7	9.7	39.6
	Neutral (neither yes nor no)	188	16.8	16.8	56.4
	Agree	423	37.8	37.8	94.2
	Strongly agree	65	5.8	5.8	100.0
	Total	1119	100.0	100.0	

Table 5 I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes.

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Strongly disagree	429	38.3	38.3	38.3
	Agree to some extent	88	7.9	7.9	46.2
	Neutral (neither yes nor no)	176	15.7	15.7	61.9
	Agree	386	34.5	34.5	96.4
	Strongly agree	40	3.6	3.6	100.0
	Total	1119	100.0	100.0	

These findings highlight the importance of balancing digital and traditional teaching methods to accommodate diverse student preferences. Understanding the reasons behind student resistance or enthusiasm for technology is crucial for developing effective instructional strategies. In cases where negative attitudes stem from limited digital literacy or past experiences, targeted support and training may help bridge the gap. By addressing these factors, educators can create more inclusive and adaptable learning environments that foster both engagement and progress (Figure 1).

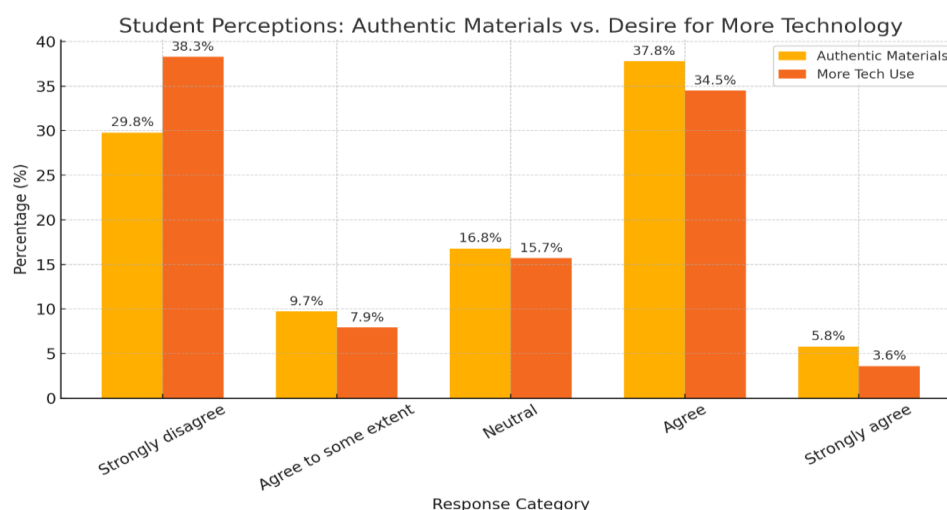


Figure 1 Student perception.

The data indicates that students perceive a relatively low use of authentic materials in their language classes, with a mean score of 2.80—slightly below the neutral point—suggesting only moderate agreement on their presence. The standard deviation of 1.365 points to a moderate range of opinions among students. Similarly, the average score for the desire for more technology use is 2.57, indicating a slight tendency toward disagreement or neutrality (Table 6). This suggests that students are not strongly in favor of increasing technology in language teaching. However, the standard deviation of 1.385 reflects a range of views, with some students likely supportive of greater tech integration. Overall, these results point to mixed perceptions and underline the need for more consistent and responsive teaching practices.

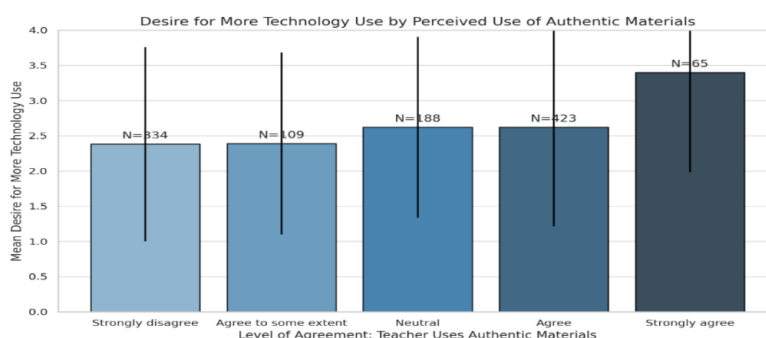
Table 6 Descriptive Statistics.

	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding.	1119	1	5	2.80	1.365
I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes.	1119	1	5	2.57	1.385
Valid N (listwise)	1119				

This report examines how students' perceptions of their teachers' use of authentic materials relate to their desire for more technology integration in language classes. Students who strongly disagreed that their teacher uses authentic materials reported the lowest desire for more technology ($M = 2.38$), while those who strongly agreed showed the highest desire ($M = 3.40$) (Table 7). This reveals a positive trend: as perceived use of authentic materials increases, so does the desire for technological enhancement. It suggests that students exposed to real-world, engaging content may be more open to or expect digital tools as part of their learning. Therefore, educators who already use authentic materials effectively might consider expanding their use of technology, as both seem to positively influence student perceptions (Figure 2).

Table 7 Report: Relationship Between Perceived Use of Authentic Materials and Desire for More Technology in Language Classes.

I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes.				
	Mean	N	Std. Deviation	
Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding.				
Strongly disagree	2.38	334	1.380	
Agree to some extent	2.39	109	1.291	
Neutral (neither yes nor no)	2.62	188	1.284	
Agree	2.62	423	1.404	
Strongly agree	3.40	65	1.412	
Total	2.57	1119	1.385	

**Figure 2** Desire for more technology use through the perceived use of authentic materials.

These findings support the idea that students who appreciate engaging, real-world materials also tend to value technology as a further enhancement in their learning environment.

3.6. Correlation analysis

To assess the relationship between the two key variables (use of authentic materials and desire for more technology), *Spearman's correlation coefficient* (r) was calculated. This method measures the strength and direction of the linear relationship between two variables. A positive correlation would suggest that as students perceive more use of authentic materials in their classes, they are also more likely to desire more technology in language teaching.

3.6.1. Variables

Use of authentic materials (videos, articles, audio).
Desire for more technology in language teaching.

3.6.2. Hypotheses (for Spearman's rho correlation)

Null Hypothesis (H_0): There is no significant monotonic relationship between students' perceptions of the teacher's use of authentic materials and their desire for more use of technology in language classes.
 $H_0: \rho = 0$

Alternative Hypothesis (H_1): There is a significant positive monotonic relationship between students' perceptions of the teacher's use of authentic materials and their desire for more use of technology in language classes.
 $H_1: \rho > 0$

A Spearman's rho correlation was conducted to examine the relationship between students' perceptions of their teacher's use of authentic materials (e.g., videos, articles, audio) and their desire for increased use of technology in language classes. The results revealed a weak but statistically significant positive correlation, $p(1119) = .132, p < .001$. This suggests that students who perceive greater use of authentic materials are slightly more likely to express interest in enhanced technological integration in their language learning. The positive coefficient indicates a monotonic relationship, and since the p-value is below the significance threshold of 0.01, the null hypothesis is rejected in favor of the alternative hypothesis: students who perceive more use of authentic materials also tend to desire more technology use (Table 8).

Table 8 Correlations.

			Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding.	I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes.
Spearman's rho	Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding.	Correlation	1.000	.132**
		Coefficient	.	<.001
		Sig. (2-tailed)	1119	1119
	I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes.	Correlation	.132**	1.000
		Coefficient	<.001	.
		Sig. (2-tailed)	1119	1119

** . Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

To further explore this relationship, a one-sample t-test was conducted to determine whether students' mean responses significantly differed from the neutral midpoint ($M = 3$) on two items: perceived use of authentic materials (Column A) and desire for more technology integration (Column B). The null hypothesis (H_0) posits no significant difference between the sample means and the neutral point, while the alternative hypothesis (H_a) suggests a statistically significant difference.

Before running the test, the assumptions for the t-test were considered: independence of responses, approximate normality of data distribution, and homogeneity of variance. The significance level was set at $p < .05$. Results from the t-test, along with the correlation analysis, provide insight into student attitudes, suggesting that while both variables show moderate disagreement overall, there is a meaningful link between the two. These findings reinforce the idea that perceived engagement through authentic materials may increase students' openness to technological enhancement in the classroom.

For the item "*I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes*," students reported a significantly lower mean score ($M = 2.57, SD = 1.39$) compared to the neutral test value of 3, $t(1118) = -10.36, p < .001$. The 95% confidence interval for the mean difference was $[-0.51, -0.35]$, indicating a statistically significant tendency toward disagreement and highlighting a notable desire for increased technology use in language instruction. Similarly, for the item "*Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding*," the mean score was also significantly below the neutral midpoint ($M = 2.80, SD = 1.37$), $t(1118) = -4.91, p < .001$, with a 95% confidence interval of $[-0.28, -0.12]$. This suggests that students perceive authentic materials as moderately underused in the classroom. Taken together, these results indicate that students are not fully satisfied with current instructional practices, particularly in relation to technology. Although both items show statistically significant departures from neutrality, the larger effect size associated with the technology item points to a stronger concern in this area and a clear opportunity for pedagogical improvement (Table 9).

Table 9 One-Sample Test.

	t	df	Test Value = 3				
			Significance		Mean Difference	95% Confidence Interval of the Difference	
			One-Sided p	Two-Sided p		Lower	Upper
I would like to see more use of technology in teaching in language classes.	-10.362	1118	<.001	<.001	-.429	-.51	-.35
Our teacher uses various authentic materials (videos, articles, audio) to improve our understanding.	-4.906	1118	<.001	<.001	-.200	-.28	-.12

4. Results

This study examined the relationship between students' perceptions of their teachers' use of authentic materials and their interest in increased technology use in language classes. A Spearman's correlation showed a weak but significant positive association ($p = .132, p < .001$), suggesting that students who value authentic materials are slightly more likely to support greater tech integration. The small effect size implies other factors, such as digital literacy or prior exposure, may also shape

attitudes toward technology. T-test results revealed significant dissatisfaction with both technology use and authentic materials, with a stronger concern expressed for technology. These findings highlight the complementary role of real-world content and digital tools in engaging learners and point to a shared preference for more student-centered, relevant teaching approaches.

5. Discussion

The findings reveal a modest but significant connection between students' appreciation for authentic materials and their support for incorporating technology in language education. This suggests that blending real-world content with digital tools can enhance learner engagement and motivation. Educators and curriculum designers may find value in integrating these elements to create more relevant and stimulating learning experiences. By combining authentic materials with technological advancements, language instruction can better meet the needs of modern learners and ultimately improve educational outcomes.

This study identified a weak but statistically significant correlation between students' perceptions of authentic materials and their desire for greater technology integration in language classrooms. While the correlation is modest, it reveals that students who experience engaging, real-world content are more likely to support the use of digital tools in their learning. This finding aligns with research by (Gilmore, 2007b) and Erbaggio et al. (Erbaggio et al., 2012), who observed that learners tend to respond positively to blended methods (Tomlinson, 2023) that merge authenticity with interactivity. Such synergy appears rooted in students' desire for instruction that mirrors real-world communication (Qureshi et al., 2023), valuing lessons that are not only academically relevant but also dynamically presented (Pérez-Jorge et al., 2025). In this context, technology serves as a natural extension of authentic learning, helping to bridge the gap between classroom practice and lived linguistic experiences (Zou et al., 2025); (Lai, 2023).

Despite the positive trend, the correlation strength ($p = .132$) suggests the relationship between these variables is modest, implying the presence of multiple influencing factors. Student attitudes toward technology may be shaped by their digital literacy skills (Zakir et al., 2025), previous exposure to educational technology, or the socioeconomic conditions of their learning environment (Rebolledo Font De La Vall & González Araya, 2023b). For many students, especially those in under-resourced schools, limited access to devices or internet connectivity may dampen enthusiasm for digital integration, regardless of its pedagogical potential (Timotheou et al., 2023). As Balalle (Balalle, 2024b) emphasizes, infrastructure and digital confidence significantly shape students' readiness to engage with technology-based instruction. Thus, perceptions are not merely about preference they are also conditioned by context.

These findings underscore the importance of blended instructional strategies that balance traditional and digital modes of delivery. Authentic materials, while valuable, may have limited impact if they are not integrated through multimedia or interactive formats that resonate with today's learners. Students increasingly expect technology-enhanced experiences, including videos, podcasts, and virtual tasks, especially when these are aligned with culturally relevant and accessible content (Motteram, 2013; Shen et al., 2024). The use of contextually rich digital tools not only promotes comprehension but also boosts motivation and engagement. This integrative approach supports communicative language teaching (Richards & Rodgers, 2001), reinforcing calls for multimodal, learner-centered instruction that reflects the diverse realities of 21st-century learners (Taglieber, 2008).

While the results are in line with global research affirming the value of authenticity and technology in education, they also present a surprising contrast: students in this study showed lower enthusiasm for increased technology use than learners in other international contexts (Hongsa et al., 2024; Huda et al., 2023). This divergence may be attributed to contextual barriers within Albania's education system, such as limited infrastructure, uneven teacher training, and the partial implementation of competence-based reforms (Anderson-Levitt et al., 2017). Such limitations likely restrict students' experiences with educational technology, shaping their expectations and receptiveness. These results point to the need for further investigation into how improved access, digital literacy programs, and curricular adjustments can enhance the synergy between authentic materials and technology in Albanian classrooms.

5.1. Research significance and contributions

This research contributes to the field of foreign language teaching by addressing an important gap in the literature on how authentic materials and technology can be integrated to improve learning outcomes, specifically within the context of Albanian secondary education. By focusing on student perceptions and using robust statistical analysis, this study provides concrete evidence of the relationship between these two critical factors. Furthermore, it offers practical recommendations that can be directly applied in classrooms, curriculum development, and educational policy.

Many students continue to find comfort in traditional methods such as textbooks and face-to-face instruction, relying on familiar routines that offer structure and clarity. While they recognize the potential benefits of technology, some view it as a source of distraction or added complexity in the learning process. This hesitation is often reinforced by limited access to digital tools, particularly in rural or underfunded schools where resources are scarce. At the same time, students tend to value

authentic materials because they see a direct connection to real-world communication and practical language use. In contrast, technology is sometimes perceived as less immediately relevant, especially when its role in enhancing language skills is not clearly demonstrated.

5.2. Originality

The originality of this research lies in its unique contextual focus, innovative approach to analyzing the relationship between authentic materials and technology, and practical implications for improving foreign language teaching in Albania. By bridging the gap between theory and practice, this study provides valuable insights into how these factors can be strategically integrated to enhance student engagement, motivation, and overall language competence.

This study holds significant value for improving foreign language education on multiple levels. By exploring the link between authentic materials and technology use, it offers guidance for enhancing curriculum design with more dynamic and engaging content. The findings can also support teacher professional development by encouraging educators to innovate and integrate digital tools into their instructional practices. On a broader scale, the research has implications for educational policy, helping decision-makers invest wisely in technology and training initiatives. Importantly, it highlights the need to consider students' preferences and perceptions when designing learning environments. In doing so, it promotes a more student-centered approach that fosters motivation, participation, and meaningful learning experiences.

6. Conclusions

This study aimed to examine the relationship between students' perceptions of the use of authentic materials and their desire for increased technology integration in foreign language instruction in Albanian secondary education. The results revealed a weak but statistically significant positive correlation between the two variables, suggesting that students who value authentic materials are slightly more inclined to support the use of technology in language learning. Descriptive and inferential statistics also indicated that students perceive both authentic materials and technology as underutilized in current classroom practices. These findings confirm the relevance of integrating authentic content and digital tools to foster communicative and expressive competence. The study contributes to a better understanding of learner preferences and offers insights for improving language teaching through balanced, student-centered strategies. Future research should explore contextual factors such as access to technology and teacher training, which may influence students' attitudes and instructional effectiveness.

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Ethical considerations

This study was conducted in accordance with ethical guidelines for research involving human participants. Informed consent was obtained from all participants prior to data collection. Participation was voluntary, and anonymity and confidentiality were guaranteed. The questionnaire used in the study did not include any personal identifiers. The research protocol was reviewed and approved by the institutional ethics committee of the Faculty of Foreign Languages, University of Tirana.

Conflict of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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